And also in the works is a Digital India Act, to replace the ageing Information Technology Act. All of these new laws will more strongly regulate the sector that's actually driving a billion Indians online: social media.

UNSOCIAL MEDIA

Social media in India grows briskly each year, in numbers and intensity. But there's a time when the battleground really shifts online: the year before India's general election. Yes, that's 2023.

The next election will be fought largely on social media, and the fireworks will be intense, in this polarised and divided nation. India and Indians have a famously thin skin online, ready to take offence at any provocation, however tiny, with law enforcement ready and waiting to arrest social media users, especially troublesome fact-checkers, for such crimes as posting a screenshot from an old Hindi movie. The largely thankless job of fact-checking will be especially under pressure as disinformation explodes, again, and blocking orders spike again.

The government ordered the blocking of nearly 10,000 social media accounts in 2020, versus fewer than 500 in 2014. These aren't tweets or posts, but entire accounts, and we can safely expect blocking orders to spike in 2023. There will be few challengers. Twitter did bravely challenge 39 blocking orders in the Karnataka High Court, saying it violated free speech. The central government was not amused, accusing it of miserable non-compliance with laws and of being frivolous and motivated, and hinting that Twitter could lose its 'safe harbour' protection, which exempts intermediaries from liability for third-party content on their platforms. It doesn't help that new owner Elon Musk has led Twitter, globally, into a train wreck with little chance of recovery.

Nor has Meta had a great time in India of late, despite its famed proximity to the ruling party and the government. It had three leadership exits in November, including the India heads of Meta and WhatsApp, in the same month that CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced 11,000 layoffs amounting to 13 per cent of global staff.

Even so, Meta remains the most influential operator of social media platforms in India, with WhatsApp remaining the go-to platform for political outreach in the run-up to 2024, and Facebook playing a key role too. And WhatsApp remains the go-to app for over 400 million Indians, the closest we have to a super-app, though its payments offering has been restricted by quasi-regulator NPCI capping the user numbers for WhatsApp Pay to 20 million, 40 million, and now 100 million.

AS INDIANS GET MORE DEPENDENT ON DIGITAL ACCESS FOR LIFE AND WORK, **THEY CAN SUDDENLY BE CUT OFF** FROM IT ALL

THE DARK SIDE: SHUTTING IT ALL DOWN

What does it mean for citizens to be dependent on digital platforms and services that can be shut down—sometimes simply via shutting off the internet? What does it mean for them to be enrolled on massive national digital platforms, sometimes with little or no informed choice?

The platforms clearly have a purpose and good intentions. CoWIN enabled the biggest vaccination programme in the world. UPI has transformed payments in India. Ayushman Bharat aims to make healthcare affordable and accessible, and leverage health history better for treatment.

The massive interlinking via Aadhaar holds the first vulnerability: hacker attacks can access bulk personal and biometric information of citizens, launch social engineering attacks, use the data to infiltrate other systems such as banking, or target government officials or high net worth individuals. Healthcare records, such as those likely stolen from AIIMS in 2022, are especially valuable to hackers and blackmailers.

Let's not just blame hackers. The state or its actors or employees could also misuse such information for surveillance, or other unauthorised activities. India has poor controls on law enforcement access to data and metadata, and next to no citizen resistance against data demands from government officials.

And yes, as India gets a billion citizens online on to a dozen platforms, there will be internet shutdowns bringing life to a grinding halt for them. In 2023, India is likely to remain on top of that global list of infamy—for the world's largest number of internet shutdowns.

As Indians get more dependent on digital access for life and work—for payments, shopping, calling for cabs or ordering in food, access to healthcare—they can suddenly be cut off from it all. Between 2017 and 2022, there were over 630 internet shutdowns tracked by the Software Freedom Law Centre's InternetShutdowns.in website. The reasons ranged from law and order issues to preventing cheating in exams. Over 400 shutdowns were in Jammu and Kashmir alone. Imagine the impact on life there—and the reluctance of citizens to depend on digital India. And imagine businesses, such as cab services or food delivery, that are purely dependent on mobile internet access. They come to a grinding halt.

In the year India becomes the world's most populous country, this nation will be online—except for underserved communities, including women, especially rural women and the citizens and services affected by internet shutdowns.

Digital infrastructure will make all key services more accessible for citizens, but increase their vulnerability to online crime and the whims of the state. Digital India, the world's biggest ongoing digital experiment, will be closely watched by the world in 2023. ■